

and Such [naming one of the great blue-chip stocks of the day] is down close to two hundred from three hundred and fifty, where it was selling only two months ago. It may sound fantastic, but I believe there is a chance it may yet touch a hundred and fifty. If we could buy ten thousand shares at a hundred and fifty, don't you all think that it would be the sort of bargain which may never be seen again? It probably will never happen, but shouldn't we be prepared, if the opportunity comes?"

At this forceful suggestion, courage ran about the room like a licking flame. Vigorous assents were given, and color came into wan cheeks.

"Put that down," said someone to the young order clerk who was present. "Buy ten thousand Such and Such at a hundred and fifty, open order."

The kid who was addressed obediently leaned forward to write, but as he did so he puckered his lips a little. Very low—but audibly—he gave that distinctive, rubbery sound of contempt which is vulgarly known as "the bird."

Immediately everyone felt less confident. Somehow or other the discussion was reopened, and after a time the suggestion was abandoned.

My informant on this matter has estimated that that little noise saved the trust a matter of three quarters of a million dollars. But no one ever thanked the boy, because no one ever dared admit that he had had anything to do with the decision to cancel that ruinous order.

Once upon a time there was an investment trust of the stuff dreams are made on. It was everything that other trusts are not. Its guiding genius was a young fellow who was everything I have said a Wall Street man could not be. Its stated principle (I quote from memory) was something to this effect:

It is the belief of the management of this corporation that a well-diversified list of carefully selected securities, held over a period of time, will *not* increase in value.

The young man's performance was even more startling than his principles. At his untimely death in 1931 his invest-